Community-Governed Data for Nonprofit Accountability

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> "Institutions don't deserve to survive. People do." — Sydette Harry, technologist & cultural critic

The quote above lines up with my personal experience. After a year-long battle with the Social Security Administration, I'd finally begun receiving Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) — which made me eligible for a coveted spot in one of my city's supportive housing programs. I was grateful to finally have a roof over my head. But my apartment had significant problems.

During a regularly scheduled home visit with my housing case manager, I pointed out what, by then, were ongoing problems that impacted my ability to live comfortably. I had black mold creeping down the walls, roaches feasting off the remnants of toothpaste on my toothbrush, and a mouse infestation so profound they would fight each other in the middle of the floor. She took a mental inventory of it all and admitted: "We're probably going to have to move you guys out. If the funders saw this, they would ask why they're paying money for you to live here."

I was speechless. I wondered: are you really so devoid of a moral compass that you need a *funder* to tell you I'm living in a slum building?

Her response points to the beating heart of this project. My case manager could see some of the problems with her own eyes. But it was only the potential threat of losing funding that might mobilize her employer to act. Accountability ran upward — to funders, not to me, a supportive housing tenant. The community a nonprofit exists to serve is the last asked whether an intervention worked, and the least able to demand change when it doesn't.

As of 2016, the United States had about 1.54 million registered nonprofits, 1.08 million of them public charities, together contributing roughly $1.05 trillion to the economy — 5.6% of GDP (NCCS, 2020). By 2022, nonprofits employed 12.8 million people, 9.9% of all private-sector jobs (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2024). In 2018, private giving reached $427.71 billion (Giving USA Foundation, 2019, as cited in NCCS, 2020), with governments routing billions more through nonprofits to deliver housing, health care, food, and schooling.

Nonprofits are embedded in the core of American life, trusted to support our most vulnerable people. We extend that trust almost entirely on faith.

Look closely, and the accountability holding that trust up is much less substantive than it appears.

Almost everything the public knows about a charity comes from its IRS Form 990 — a form the organization fills out about itself, with little independent verification. Watchdogs rate a sliver of the sector; the rest runs on self-report. When nonprofits fail to police themselves, the potential for abuse is real: studies put fraud losses near 5% of revenue a year, with nonprofits about a tenth of reported cases and a $69,000 median loss (Association of Certified Fraud Examiners [ACFE], 2026) — raised in the name of people who never see it.

Rarer than fraud but more corrosive: the sector is judged by overhead, not by results (BBB Wise Giving Alliance et al., 2013). Nonprofits count outputs — meals served, clients enrolled, beds filled — because outputs are what funders ask for. Few have the systems to track outcomes: whether people were housed and stayed housed, whether anything in their lives changed. That difference is the whole game, and it is the part the system is built to skip.

This is structural. Accountability flows upward. An institution answers to the people who can defund its programs. It does not, in any binding way, answer to the people it serves — they have no check to withhold, no seat at the table, no standing to say its report is a lie (Ebrahim, 2010).

So every year nonprofits divert millions, undercut radical movements, and leave communities beholden to funders who never face what they face. The people who know best whether a program works — the tenants in the mold-streaked apartments — are the one group the system is built not to hear.

That is the problem worth solving: accountability that points the wrong way.

The collective

I didn't want anyone's dignity to depend on a funder's assessment of a problem. That's why I helped build this collective.

The collective is a team of community members, people who collect, manage, and analyze data, and people with experience in user experience design. We end the era of accountability that runs only from nonprofits to funders. We co-create the truth about the institutions claiming to save communities.

We build a community-governed data stack that community members own. The community defines effectiveness, defines metrics, and governs its data. The model is for the whole sector: wherever public money and public trust are spent on people's behalf, the people should hold the record.

We prove it where the stakes are starkest first. This residency applies the stack to supportive housing nonprofits in New York City — drawing on municipal and property logs, federal data like HUD's Homeless Management Information System, and community voice captured through audio, video, transcription, and qualitative analysis. Supportive housing is the first proving ground; it will not be the last.

What we build

We bring collaborative mapping, story-based evaluation, and downward accountability into the rooms where funding and policy are decided.

A nonprofit reports to the city that its tenants are stably housed. Our stack lets those tenants speak — and surfaces that half live with broken appliances, non-working elevators, or violence. That gap, between the reported and the lived, is leverage.

We help communities take their own data to funders and into direct public action. Every feature is co-designed with the community members who will use it — because accountability tools only work when the people holding power to account build them.

Institutions don't deserve to survive. People do. The sector claims to serve people; it answers to funders. The collective turns that accountability back around — putting the record in the hands of the people who live with the outcomes, and making the truth they already know impossible to file away.

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